MATTEO MUSCAS

Ceilings.



A SHORT COLLECTION OF POEMS

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The Nerd Side.

The nerd side.

(…) simply turn the pages until a paragraph catches your eye. If the ideas or images seem interesting scan the nearby paragraphs for anything that resonates an intriguing way. Fairly soon, I hope, the fog will clear, and the underlying narrative will reveal itself. In effect, you will be reading the book in the way it was written.

(JG Ballard)

The nerd side. During the poetry module I have just finished attending, I decided to unleash my inner nerd. Maybe *decided* is not the right term though. It simply *happened*. I set myself on studying math, biology and astronomy. I bought physics textbooks. They would have all been the new topic for my poems, or at least, this is what I wanted to do in the first place. The objective was to pursue, for once, what I really like to talk about, instead of whining like a little bitch about depressing subjects like I usually do (I knew it wasn't going to work).

The idiot's approach to science poetry.

(from a note-to-self written in mid-December).

There is something wrong with the format of the first two poems. I'm happy with what I wrote – maybe just a bit of tuning of the imagery is required *(turns up the "Imagery" knob)*. I'm happy with the scientific explanations. I'm happy with what the page looks like. And yet for some reason the whole is less than the sum of the parts. They are distracting. People have trouble reading it. I should change something.

Influential works (I). *Tangent Lines* uses the same narrative tone and a similar voice to *Amanda Barker* by Edgar Lee Masters.

Henry got me with child,

Knowing that I could not bring forth life

Without losing my own.

In youth therefore I entered the portals of dust.

Traveler, it is believed in the village where I lived

That Henry loved me with a husband's love,

But I proclaim from the dust

That he slew me to gratify his hatred.

Trial and error. I like to experiment with what's on the page. A small detour: Steve Jobs, one of the co-founders of Apple Computers, followed a calligraphy course that helped him discovering his love for design and eventually the importance of beauty. Eventually, when I write my poetic manifesto, one of the bullet points will be "Poems have to look beautiful on the page". I want to create *visual-paper poetry*, in which the choice of paper, the look and feel, and the font are as important as the words that compose the poem. I want my readers to be both visually astonished and poetically impressed. I need them to love the details.

Poetic Rants (I). Welcome, my unfriend, to a new kind a poetry, driven by a destructive wave of pessimism, hatred for the conventional artistic *intelligentsia*, the intellectual elite that is holding poetry strapped to a chair, hidden in sub-basements in libraries, absent from the everyday life, ignored by the media, a white fly in the e-book stores.

Extended metaphors.

Centuries ago there lived—

"A king!" my little readers will say immediately.

No, children, you are mistaken. Once upon a time there was a *poet*. It was not an expensive piece of *wood*. Far from it. Just a common *Birkbeck* student, one of those thick, solid logs that are put in a *classroom* in winter to make cold rooms cozy and warm.

I do not know how this really happened; yet the fact remains that one fine day this piece of *student* found *himself* in the shop of an old carpenter.

The Pinocchio Metaphor. (Poetry of the everyday.) In which I discovered that everything is poetry. The violence of the ordinary, the beauty of an instant, a waitress taking a drink off your table. Poetry is for those who are keen to watch, for those who'd like to analyze, dissect, discover. The wonderful water-paint of what goes around you. It's *knowledge*. Ironically though, this definition also applies to science.

Fragments from an unwritten manifesto.

The *(name still to be chosen)* will therefore refuse the artistic establishment, which put pains thousand-fold upon the poets, hurled in some late evening reading.

Anti-establishment. There is this nightmare I have some nights. I'm standing in front of an audience. Someone has just announced my name, my academic background and the title of a poem I wrote. I clear my throat and start reading random words I put together from random pages of an evening paper the previous night, making sure no actual meaning could be found. After two minutes of painful gibberish, everyone applauses. A guy rubs his chin and nods in approval. Nobody has any idea what has just happened, what they have heard.

No progress. (No substance.) I can't seem to find a way to make the science poems work well on page. I might need to move to some other project.

Poetic Rants (II). This has to change, unfriends. Poetry should be brief, immediate, meaningful. It should educate and thrill. It should consider astronomy and Jersey Shore, at the same time if necessary. We have spent too long already, unfellow colleagues, revolving around obscure metaphors, conceptual works, arrogant post-after-post modernism.

Unsolved questions. Can poetry express more than just the imperfect mirror of the troubled soul of the Poet?

Dead Poets Society (I). I'm sitting on my sofa thinking about Homer (the Greek, not the Springfieldian). About the way epic poems have been massively influential for the development of Greek and Latin cultures and therefore, indirectly, for most of the western political thought for the centuries to come. Iliad and Odyssey were major breakthroughs in tale telling. They played a major role in *educating* people and in *transforming* an oral tradition in something new.

We came a long way since Homer.

Poetic Rants (III). So let's get political, Poets! Let's talk about feelings, leftovers, anything and everything. Let's show the world we can transmit knowledge and passion in talking about McDonald's sandwiches and subatomic particles. Let's get influential, popular, widespread. Let's get common. Let's represent workers and the unemployed. Let's make ourselves understood. Let's be relevant and trash the artists. Let's all become craftsmen, for once in history.

Rage Against the Machine. What happened to poetry? When did it start spinning compulsively around itself up to point of drowning in a bathtub full of pretentious artistic vomit? Did we hand in all our critical thought to somebody else's hands? Latin-American and Mediterranean poets have had a leading role in standing up against totalitarianisms. I'm not sure about the entirety of the world, but Italians definitely did give up talking about freedom, hunger, liberty, power. Poetry should be opposition, innovation, activism. Stop acting intellectual, people, and get down to work.

Dead Poets Society (II). Beyond the religious reasons, Dante Alighieri had to write *The Divine Comedy* after finding a version 2.0 of his faith in God. The Italian author also delivers a strong political critique and a ruthless satyr of the artists of his time, providing a meticulously detailed description of Paradise, Purgatory and Hell while skating graciously through the allegories he built. If this is not inspirational, then I'm not quite sure what it is.

Nice guys finish last. (The people of paper.) Oh, the irony! I have finally found a way to make it work and it's too late. I shouldn't have abandoned the science project all together. It could have given me so much satisfaction. Thankfully my Sardinian side-project is giving me good results.

Wacky ideas about converting everything ever written by human beings, including post-it notes, into digital form. Something poets know extremely well is, given the limited market poetry has, the joy of self-publishing and finding alternative channels of communication. What poets may have not realized just yet is having a strong presence online. Self-publishing is cool, but the audience is limited. *Amazon* and *iBooks Store* are a huge opportunity and a bright spotlight for those who can make it work. Poets may want to look in that direction more firmly. I, personally, definitely want to.

Solved questions. Yes.

It's funny 'cos it's true. Avant-garde has been the furnace of poetic revolution during the last century. Some of the authors who've influenced me the most shared a new idea of what poetry should be and convey. With their methods, they sent a message through. Then something happened.

All those styles melted together, and not necessarily for the best. Is avant-garde no more than a style now? Why did all those styles lose their push forward? Personally, my idea is that somewhere down the road we lost the need of communicating and picked up an *I'm-just-gonna-try-to-surprise-you-with-some-artsy-alakazam* hitchhiker.

Innovation ceases to exist once it becomes canon.

Standing on the shoulders of the giants. During this last year, I have read so much poetry that I don't even remember it all. I have extensively read Bukowski, Dante, Whitman. I know from the inside out the *Spoon River Anthology* by Edgar Lee Masters. Thousands of haiku and tanka. Elizabeth Smart, with *By Grand Central Station I Sat Down and Wept* played an important role in discovering my love for prose poems (or pseudo-prose ones rather).

Science and Poetry, by Mary Midgley, had such a strong influence that I could just trash this paper and start a new one that simply link you to a copy of the book (I'm not going to, in case anyone worries). And then experimental fiction and graphic novels and more poetry: JG Ballard, Einlein, Craig Thompson, T.S. Eliot.

Developing *the blues*. After my idea of a consistent strong scientific theme crashed against an even stronger wall of reality, I had to move on to something different. In a few days I would have flown back to my hometown, Cagliari, in Sardinia. Travelling usually has a positive effect on my creativity, so I decided I could have given myself a short break and see what would come out. I knew going back home would have been a sweet and sour feeling. A relative of mine was going to pass away pretty soon. Furthermore, I feel like I have mixed feelings about my homeland. All my friends and relatives are there, and Sardinia has some amazing landscapes to offer. All the kind of stuff that can boost anyone's inspiration. On the other hand I can't help but think Sardinia is a pit hole of problems, given the Italian political and economic instability.

My prediction was right. I decided to change my plans on the run and talk about my love/hate relationship with Sardinia, focusing on the idea of not feeling myself at home, neither there nor in the U.K.

Influential works (V). Use of dialogues in *In the Woods* uses the same narrative structure as the dialogues in *By Grand Central Station I Sat Down and Wept* by Elizabeth Smart. (p.76)

I drank my coffee, but I had a slight feeling of nausea. It's to be expected, I don't mind it at all, it's nothing.

My love, are you feeling better?

He can't talk, only mutter.

O my dear, O my dear, drink a little milk, lie down and rest a little. I will comfort you, I can carry love like Saint Christopher. It is heavy but I can carry it.

Thoughts on things I have learned in class. There is something that links all poets together. It touches Whitman as well as Bukowski, and Baudelaire, and the surrealists and the Dadaists and the futurists. It is something none of us can avoid. It is the *living in the now* and the struggle that comes with it. Despite having different ways of consumption and different criticisms, all kinds of poetry comes from a same starting point: an observation - whether this is regarding the world or the inner self. This is possibly the most valuable observation I have made during these long two terms. Going back to reading my own works and examining what everyone has written in classes and workshops made me realize that even though my group had an excellent variety of styles, we all started from the same common ground: observing the world.

Influential works (IV). A Japanese haiku, *Weather* by Nishiwaki Junzaburo, inspired the ending of *Cold Tall Ceiling*. (p.189)

Morning like an upturned jewel:

A man murmuring with someone at the door –

Birthday of the gods.

Observing the world. Wherein Matteo, wishful of providing a comparison between the scientific poems and *Sardinian Winter Blues*, takes into consideration how both works have a strong root in the *everyday world*, there is clearly a much larger use of extended metaphors in the former, as I couldn't waste a chance to mix something common and immediate with a touch of science fiction. The mantra after all is: "Work on your voice, Matteo. Work on different voices. Work on different voices inside the same poem."

Everything is affected like within a magnetic field.

Influential works (II). Walt Whitman's observation about the world and the inner self, with a minor mix between love and science.

(*From Song of Myself, W. Whitman)*

I celebrate myself, and sing myself,

And what I assume you should assume,

For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.

Thou Reader.

Thou reader throbbest life and pride and love the same

as I,

Therefore for thee the following chants.

Influential works (III). Another reference to *death* and the *end*.

(From The Hollow Men, T.S. Eliot.)

This is the way the world ends

This is the way the world ends

This is the way the world ends

Not with a bang but a whimper.

The interrogation room.

You, poor student with a wobbly English, just stood up and criticize contemporary poetry in its entirety.

I- I am aware of it.

You should get off your high horse, boy.

I know I may sound patronizing. I'm well aware of it. I *did* face the possibility of lying and soften my ideas. Give some less extremist views.

Why didn't you, then?

I had a tutorial and the outcome was that I should write about where I want to go my poetry. Trust me, I don't want to sound like one of those pretentious artsy fucks that I criticize; I simply believe that some branches of modern poetry, especially concrete and visual poetry, focus too much on stupefying the audience and on expressing sensation rather than conveying meaning.

You'll regret your anti-radical-chic views. A group of visual poets is already on its way here to beat you up with their MacBooks.

Like Edith Piaf sang, *Je ne regrette rien*.

Hank. My main idea, *the whole meaning of my work*, is to carry a narrative arch through. Wow, such a breakthrough for poetry, some might say.

Yes, I would reply, ignoring the subtle sarcasm implied in that answer. Yes, it is a breakthrough. Mostly because I feel contemporary poetry is losing the pleasure of providing a consistent narration, shipwrecked by too many different styles and artistic and social movements.

It is definitely not a coincidence the poets I quoted up to now have all worked with extended narrative schemes. What Dante, Homer, Eliot, Whitman and Smart really have in common is that *they all tell stories*. In very different ways indeed, but they all do. Henry Charles Bukowski, to me, sums up all my ideas of what poetry should be. (Again, such a heavy statement!)

He was highly prolific, extremely methodic; his approach was the one of a craftsman rather than an artist. Most of all though, Bukowski was a storyteller. A hell of a good one.

what?

sleepy now

at 4 a.m.

I hear the siren

of a white ambulance,

then a dog

barks

once

in this tough-boy

Christmas

morning.

Outside the Wall. I'm sitting in front of my own self, handcuffed. A spotlight over my eyes, an interviewer I can't see but his silhouette. There is a question I have been avoiding up until now – now that the sound of keys tapped on a laptop steals oxygen to a word count getting thinner and thinner with each stroke.

Where do you go from here? Voice asks.

Obviously nowhere, as I'm handcuffed to the table.

Are you *sure*?

And there I am, standing, my hands untied, the door is open.

I've come a long way since September. I thought a lot, I read a lot, I wrote a lot.

I decided I'd put myself in the mental frame of a total critique, about me, about poets, about poems, about poetry. I thought the complete denial of what I believed poetry should be would have helped me find my way and my voice. It worked, partially. I'm still working on my voice, but I'm down that road now.

I'm strongly opinionated about what I like and what I don't.

I'm writing my own manifesto.

Of Time and Space.

Untitled.

Glee plays on the seat mounted screen
In front of me – time slows down
Metronomically painful
Like sitting on a minute-hand
Spinning anti-clockwise.

Dictatorships and absolutisms
washed up on the shore of
an (un)stoppable
ticking clock
clock
clock.

I'm a bad astronaut on a rocket

My clock ticks on – second –

And I speed up, more than
a birdplane
more than
Elton John
reaching the speed, faster as light is.

I look at the reflection I can't see
There's no me in mirror
I sympathise with vampires
Their toothbrushes issues,
Their hair combing troubles.

He is an astronaut on a spaceship

My clock is barely moving – for him
Ten years,
Seventy years

I thereby deny future for a nanobeat.
Stepping on the dock of the bay,
Saving time.

Time Machines.

Grandma is sewing a scarf for me
The general scarf or relativity.
With her crotchet hooks
She winds spacewool into timeballs
A fabric tied together that
Can hardly be divided.

Grandma made me a spacetime scarf.
It looks like an elephant on a trampoline.
So heavy to wear.

Grandma throws it at me and the
scarf hits me and

it slows
Down

and

bends

and
stops.

Sardinian Winter Blues.

SARDINIAN WINTER BLUES

Ceilings.

Cold tall ceilings.
Cold small hands, yours.
I wrap myself in my trench-coat.

His cold, colder body
in front of a distracted audience.
An old man perched on the pulpit –
Inaudible speech in the distance.

Grieving relatives

an easily explanation
for the Unexplainable mystery
Us here, staring at him
here no more.

There is no comfort
in the sunshine illumining -
your sleepless face.

Old woman: apparition up the aisle,
carrying a basketful of tingling
profane coins. Someone sobs.

I stare at the old lady

at all those money

She looks at me.

A cold afternoon in January.





SARDINIAN WINTER BLUES

In the woods.

She claims that after all it's not too bad. She claims. There are flies, that she gets to try and catch. Flies make her do that funny sound.
Silence.
She repeats that yes - clearing her voice - it's not all that bad.
I nod.
Moving closer, tuning down my voice. Brain tells me I would not want people to hear me. But there is nobody around.
I turn my own volume down.
Perfectly pitched, pure, empty universe.
I tell her. I tell her last time, last time I've seen her, she seems to be perfectly fine. In good appetite, she says. In good appetite, I confirm. Brain tells me to keep on talking. Brain itself replies he froze (I froze).
I scratch my head. Words come out slow, like a leaking faucet, like
water dripping on a sink at night and you forget to close the door, and you hear the sound, metronomically precise, like a japanese train, like taxes. Like a convict waiting for the hangman.

You know, I have never thought much of you.

Though you gave me food last time we saw each other.

True.

Silence joined us. Sat between us. (time near the center of a black hole). I stood, holding my mug - Awkwardness flavored tea inside,
progressively colder - between my hands.
The discomfort of a moment in all its beauty. In all its ironical
majesty.

You know. It's a shame you're gone. After all, it is.

I get on my feet, considering the possibility of carrying on our pale, stale, derailed conversation. Decided that no, interlocution time has reached its end. Light outside, unrealistically bright. Dark
paintbrushes of soft wooden brown here.
I walk to the door to open it more dramatically that I wanted to.

Take care of yourself - I say getting out.

The door closes behind me.

SARDINIAN WINTER BLUES

Small -non- talks.

the initial - and somehow -
final stage of our relationship.
of all the interesting accurate
weather dissertations.
(very cold outside, by the way. very).
millions of pages
gazillions of topics
Proust, Freud, E.L. Fucking James
in a millisecond.
we salute, only saying our names.
nodding.
and leaving.

curtain /ˈkɜː.tən/
(actors walk in)
- Matteo.
he nods.
I nod too.
- Stefano.

(curtain comes down) over us.





SARDINIAN WINTER BLUES

Born into this.

born in this

into this

video poker and scratch cards

unemployment and torpor

horse fillets and crab meat

welfare state and anarchy

always waiting for a train
parked elsewhere -
in a perpetual strike.

land of traditions, stubbornness
blue sky, grey grumbles,
turquoise sea, beige complaints.

I miss you, Sardinia
only from a distance.

your warm sun on my skin
I'm a stranger here, home.
I'm a stranger, there, home.

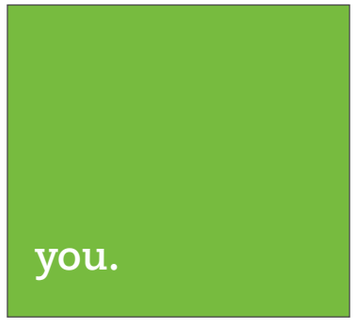
you're a siren that attracts me and shipwrecks me
your nasty, awful, charming appearance
drives me to your rotten core
to people with no hope
imagination, dreams.
Broken.

I miss you, Sardinia.
I really do. When I'm elsewhere.

SARDINIAN WINTER BLUES

Love song.





SARDINIAN WINTER BLUES

Tangent lines.

Tangent lines,
you and I.
Destined to touch
in one point
to then drift
away
forever

Lost in our journeys,
You
and I,
We meet
and fade.

We were on a boat.
A ferry boat
full of the memories
of what we used to be.
I looked for you

You were never there
You have never been

I turned around
to meet the gaze of a ghost.

I turned around and
you weren't there.

The ship sailed.

